Emergency Telephone Numbers

First Aid, Medical, or Health Unit	
Ambulance (Emergency Rescue) Service	
Hospital	
Police Department	
Fire Department	
Safety Office	
Security Office	
Hazardous Materials Spill or Leak Control Team	
Injury Compensation Control Office or Control Point	
Employee Assistance Program	800-EAP-4-YOU
(24-hour, toll-free numbers)	(800-327-4968)
	TTY: 877-492-7341
Inspection Service	877-USMAIL-5 or
(24-hour, toll-free number)	877-876-2455

Use this handbook only during regular work hours and only on Postal Service premises.

Postal Employee's Guide to Safety

Handbook EL-814 November 2013
Transmittal Letter

A. Explanation. The Postal Service® is committed to providing its employees and customers with a safe and healthy environment and complying with applicable safety laws and regulations. A key strategy in the Postal Service's Transformation Plan is building a highly effective and motivated workforce. A safe and healthy workplace, free from safety hazards, is important for helping us achieve that goal. This guide provides Postal Service employees with policies, procedures, and guidelines pertaining to safe work practices.

B. Revision. Changes in Postal Service policy required revisions to the June 2008 edition.

C. Online Availability. You may view this handbook in electronic format on the Postal Service PolicyNet Web site.

1. Go to *http://blue.usps.gov*.
2. Under "Essential Links" in the left-hand column, click *References.*
3. Under "PolicyNet" on the right-hand side, click *HBKs.*

(The direct URL for the Postal Service PolicyNet Web site is *http://blue.usps.gov/cpim.)*

D. Ordering Instructions. You may order printed copies of Handbook EL-814 from the Material Distribution Center (MDC) using Touch Tone Order Entry (TTOE). Call 800-273-1509.

Note: You must be registered to use TTOE. To register, call 800-332-0317, select option 1, extension 2925, and follow the prompts to leave a message. (Wait 48 hours after registering before placing your first order.)

E. Comments and Questions. Address any comments and questions on the content of this handbook to:

DIRECTOR, SAFETY AND HEALTH
US POSTAL SERVICE
475 L'ENFANT PLZ SW RM 9801
WASHINGTON DC 20260-4231

F. Restriction. This material is to be used only during authorized work hours and on Postal Service premises.

G. Effective Date. This handbook is effective November 2013.



Linda DeCarlo
Director
Safety and Health

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Introduction

This booklet provides simple easy-to-locate safety rules and procedures so that you can familiarize yourself with those rules that apply to your job. The booklet is intended for reference only. It is not to be taken off Postal Service® premises and should be used only during regular work hours. The booklet is not intended to be all-inclusive, as it cannot cover all the conditions that may arise on your job. Your local office may have more specific rules to supplement these requirements.

Although the Occupational Safety and Health Administration does not cite employees for violation of their responsibilities, each employee shall comply with all occupational safety and health standards and all rules, regulations, and orders *issued under the Act* that are applicable. Occupational Safety and Health programs are generally the same as for workers in states covered by OSHA. See OSHA 3021, 1997 (Revised).

The omission of any safety information from this booklet does not reduce your personal responsibility to remain alert and use good judgment when performing your duties. If any rule or procedure is not perfectly clear to you, ask your supervisor for clarification. Learn and use all the safety rules and procedures that apply to your job. The Postal Service welcomes any suggestions you may have that might improve the safety of operations.

Submit your suggestions to your supervisor. You may wish to submit a suggestion or idea using the eIDEAS program on the Postal Service Blue page. As an alternative, you can use PS Form 1270, *Idea Proposal.*

If you observe an unsafe condition or an unsafe act, report it to your supervisor immediately. Use PS Form 1767, *Report of Hazard, Unsafe Condition, or Practice,* to document the condition. If you wish to remain anonymous, file PS Form 1767 directly with your installation's safety personnel. Without revealing your name, they will immediately give the report to your supervisor for necessary action. (In such cases, safety personnel must not disclose the name of the individual making the report.)

Section I: General Safety Rules

A. General Rules

Safety rules are for your benefit; observing safe working practices and Postal Service safety rules is a primary responsibility of all Postal Service employees. General safety rules include, but are not limited to the following rules:

- Never work under the influence of intoxicants.
- Never sell, possess, or use illegal drugs on Postal Service premises. If you are required to take physician-prescribed drugs that could impair your mental or physical abilities, you must notify your supervisor; never drive or work around moving equipment while under the influence of drugs.
- Never keep contraband material such as firearms, dangerous weapons, fireworks, intoxicants, or illegal drugs on postal premises. Never engage in horseplay, scuffling, fighting, or playing practical jokes on Postal Service premises. Do not run in Postal Service facilities. Hold the handrail when walking down stairs.
- Do not toss or throw packages or bundles, unless required by the operation (e.g., culling belt, etc.).
- Observe all warning signs and notices that have been installed for your protection. Comply with all safety and health regulations, procedures, and practices, including the use of approved personal protective equipment (PPE).
- Keep your work area in a safe and healthful condition through proper maintenance of property and equipment. Immediately report safety hazards and unsafe working conditions to your supervisor.

- Keep physically and mentally fit to meet the job requirements.
- Drive defensively and professionally; extend courtesy in all situations; and obey all state, local, and Postal Service regulations (including wearing a seatbelt when driving a vehicle owned, leased, or contracted by the Postal Service).
- Observe the control of hazardous energy lockout procedures.
- Other safety rules may apply to your job. You should perform your duties in the safest possible manner at all times. If you have questions about how to do your job safely, ask your supervisor.

B. Environmental Protection

- Comply with environmental protection regulations, procedures, and practices.
- Participate in pollution prevention by recycling, reusing materials, and reducing waste.
- Conform to Clean Air Act requirements by carpooling or using public transportation.

C. Office Safety

- Keep unattended drawers and doors closed in desks, file cabinets, etc., to eliminate tripping hazards and sources of cuts or abrasions.
- Open the top drawer of a file cabinet slowly, standing to one side of the file cabinet. When you finish with one file drawer, close it before opening another.
- Fill the lowest drawer in a file cabinet first to reduce the chance of its tipping over. Place heavy objects in the bottom drawers.

- Keep the tops of file cabinets, bookcases, etc., free of files, papers, books, and any other materials.
- When seated, keep your chair firmly on the floor. Tipping it backward on its rear legs invites an accident and possible injury.
- Handle cleaning fluids with care, as some are toxic and/or flammable. See Section IV.B. for specific guidelines on handling toxic, corrosive, irritating, or flammable items.
- Keep desktop paper cutters in a closed, locked position when you are not using them.
- Adjust video display monitors, chairs, and other equipment for comfort and proper body alignment. For information on proper body positioning, see Section XII, A—E.
- Adjust video display terminals, chairs, and other equipment for maximum comfort.
- Guard office equipment with shields covering moving parts to prevent clothing, hair, and fingers from getting caught.
- Keep all debris picked up off the floor, especially rubber bands, straps, and paper clips. Keep cubicles and workstations clean, neat, and organized in a manner that presents a pleasant appearance.

1. Obstructions

- Keep all aisles clear of tripping hazards, such as wastebaskets, electrical cords, protruding utility outlets, trash, etc.
- Keep your floor area dry. If you spill water or some other liquid on the floor, wipe the floor dry immediately to eliminate possible slipping hazards. Call your supervisor for assistance when cleaning large spills.

2. Climbing

- When you must climb, use a step stool, ladder, or other equipment designed for that purpose. Do not climb onto chairs or other office furniture.

3. Lifting

- Lift with your legs instead of your back. Ask for assistance when the object is too heavy, is awkwardly shaped, or blocks your view when you carry it. See Section VII.A. for more guidelines on lifting heavy objects.

D. Elevators

- Load capacities are posted in elevators, both by pounds and by number of persons. Never exceed this limit for any reason.
- Repair an elevator only if you are qualified in elevator maintenance and repair.
- Do not use elevators during an emergency evacuation.
- Do not smoke in elevators.
- Be alert and watch your step when entering or leaving an elevator.
- Do not ride in freight elevators unless you have been authorized to do so.
- Do not use passenger elevators for freight.

E. Dock Safety

- Do not smoke anywhere on the docks or when you are loading or unloading trucks, trailers, vans, railroad cars, or any other vehicles.
- Never jump off the docks. Use approved steps or ladders.

- Close dump holes when you are not using them.
- Chock all trailers before loading or unloading them. Keep unused chocks out of walkways and stored against the dock.
- Store dock plates in an anchored, upright position.
- When using dock plates, secure them in position to keep them from slipping or sliding away.
- Always be aware of moving vehicles and equipment on the dock.

F. Rest Bars

- Rest bars are designed to support individuals in an upright backward-leaning position while working at some stationary activities. Do not use a rest bar as a stool for sitting with the cushion in the flat position. The seat can be raised or lowered in height and firmly seated at any point between 25 inches and 36 inches. Adjust the seat angle using only the slots provided in the seat support. Resting the seat support against the welded stop is not allowed.
- Keep at least one foot on the rest bar base when using the rest bar. If you put one foot on the bar rest, your foot must be *on* the bar rest rather than inside.
- After using the rest bar, fold the seat down flat and place it in a safe location, possibly near the working case. Be sure that the seat support does not stick out.

G. Personal Portable Headsets

- The use of headsets is permissible only for employees who perform duties while seated or stationary and only where headset use does not interfere with performing duties or constitutes a safety or health hazard. Do not wear or use headsets while walking or driving, while near moving machinery, while involved in oral business communications, or while in contact with or in view of the public.
- Personal portable headphones or headsets are not to be used in lieu of approved personal protective equipment in noise hazard locations.

Section II: Occupational Injury or Illness

A. Reporting Injuries or Illness

If you are injured or become ill from work-related causes, you must report immediately to your supervisor, even if the problem seems minor.

1. Treatment

- You must receive authorized medical evaluation and treatment or first aid in accordance with procedures outlined in the *Employee and Labor Relations Manual* (ELM) 543. The lack of prompt attention to even slight injuries could lead to more serious complications.

2. Reporting

- Your supervisor must contact the medical or health unit (if available) or the local emergency rescue or paramedic unit and report the type of injury and your location. Follow the procedures outlined in ELM 544. All reports must comply with the requirements of the Postal Service, the Office of Workers' Compensation Programs, and the Occupational Safety and Health Administration (OSHA).

3. Prevention

- Your supervisor must investigate and evaluate each accident and take any necessary measures to prevent the recurrence of similar incidents.

B. Treating Eye Injuries

- Do not permit a fellow employee to attempt to remove a foreign body from your eye. Have any eye injury treated immediately by professional medical personnel.
- If corrosive liquids, such as acids or other irritants, are splashed in your eyes, flush them thoroughly with clear, cold running water for 15 minutes. Call for assistance immediately (you may need help to hold your eyes open), and have the medical unit or emergency first aid facility contacted.

C. Using Emergency First Aid Telephone Numbers

- Become familiar with emergency first aid telephone numbers and the procedures for obtaining emergency first aid when needed. Use the inside cover of this handbook to list your local emergency phone numbers.
- **Immediately** notify your supervisor of any emergency.

Section III: Fire Prevention and Protection

A. Reporting Fire Hazards

Report all suspected fire hazards to your supervisor immediately.

B. Emergency Evacuation

- Become familiar with your floor plan. In case of fire, you should know the location of and how to use all fire alarm stations, and the location of all fire exits for your facility.
- Follow the directions given by the assigned emergency evacuation team members and supervisors in your area.
- Evacuate your area immediately; do not go to your locker to retrieve personal items.
- Do not use elevators during an emergency. Elevator use during an emergency evacuation is prohibited.
- Follow all fire evacuation procedures during fire drills as well as during an actual emergency.
- Your local office must provide a method or methods to get disabled or handicapped employees out safely.

C. Fire in Your Work Area

- Sound your local alarm first. Take any other required steps to alert fellow employees and the fire department to the fire.
- Do not engage in any disruptive actions or unnecessary talking that might prevent others from hearing and understanding instructions and directions.
- Move quickly, but do not run, to the nearest exit.

- Attempt to put out first-stage fires only if you have received training on how to use fire extinguishers and if you believe you can do so safely. If you have any doubt about your ability to extinguish the fire, leave the area. Remember that your own safety comes first.

D. Fire-Fighting Equipment

- Fire hoses, hydrants, and sprinkler systems are for fire-fighting purposes and are to be used by municipal fire departments only.
- Promptly report to your supervisor the existence of any used or damaged fire extinguishers.
- Do not stack or store material within 18 inches of a sprinkler head. Report any deficiencies to your supervisor immediately.
- Do not attach anything to or hang anything from any component of a sprinkler system other than materials required for the system.
- Do not lock (except with approved fire exit locking mechanisms) or obstruct exits, passageways leading to fire exits, or fire-extinguishing equipment such as fire extinguishers, alarm boxes, etc. This equipment must be kept accessible at all times.

E. Flammable Materials

- Store flammable liquids or solvents (up to 5 gallons) in approved flammable storage safety containers.
- Dispose of oily rags, or other flammable waste subject to spontaneous combustion, in closed metal containers.
- Properly label all cans to indicate their contents and store them in designated areas. Do not use spark or heat-producing devices in the vicinity of flammable liquids, vapors, or gases.

- Follow the procedures outlined in Management Instruction (MI) EL-810-2006-3, *Response to Hazardous Materials Releases,* and the guidance found in the Material Safety Data Sheets (MSDSs) for handling spills and leaks of specific products and chemicals.

F. Smoking

- Smoking is prohibited in all Postal Service facilities.
- Smoking is prohibited while collecting or delivering mail.
- Smoking is prohibited within 25 feet of gasoline pumps, gas and oil storage tanks, spray paint operations, or other operations involving flammable liquids or gases.

Section IV: Personal Safety and Protective Equipment

A. Personal Safety

1. Clothing

- Wear sensible, properly fitting clothing to work. Oversized clothing, wide-flared pants, full dresses or skirts, full or flared sleeves on shirts or blouses, neckties, scarves, loose aprons, and similar clothing can be hazardous if you work with machinery, vehicles, or moving equipment. Such clothing is not acceptable apparel for the workroom floor.
- Do not wear neckties around moving machinery or automated equipment. If you must wear a tie, wear the clip-on variety. Dress appropriately for weather conditions.

2. Jewelry

- Do not wear jewelry such as necklaces, neck chains, pins, dangling earrings, bracelets, watches, watch chains, rings, etc., around moving machinery or exposed electrical circuits.

3. Hair

- If your hairstyle restricts either your forward or peripheral vision, or if your hair can become entangled in moving machinery or equipment, tie your hair back or otherwise confine it.

4. Shoes

- Wear appropriate work shoes, whether you walk many miles on a route or handle mail in the workroom. Wear shoes that are fully enclosed at the heels, toes, and sides, made of leather or a substantial synthetic material (canvas or nylon is not acceptable). The approved footwear for uniform program employees must have the SR/USA label. See ELM 939 for exceptions.
- To eliminate slips, trips, and falls, do not wear the following types of shoes on the workroom floor:
  - Heels more than 1 1/2 inches and soles more than 1/2 inch in height.
  - Spiked heels, regardless of height.
  - Open shoes (including open sides, toes, or heels) such as thongs, sandals, mules, house slippers, clogs, wedgies, etc.
  - Heels with steel taps.
  - Shoes with cloth, nylon, or mesh-woven tops, such as tennis shoes, athletic or jogging shoes (except those with leather or leatherlike uppers), moccasins, etc.
  - Shoes no longer adequate because of disrepair.

B. Personal Protective Equipment

- A hazard assessment and equipment selection may be conducted by your supervisor in your workplace in accordance with the requirements of OSHA 1910.132—139 and Appendix B.
- Wear all personal protective equipment (PPE) required by the Postal Service or by your supervisor for the jobs or tasks that you perform. If you have questions about PPE when handling chemicals, consult with your supervisor.

1. Eye and Face Protection

- Wear eye and face protection that meets American National Standards Institute (ANSI) standards when working in areas where hazards exist that could cause eye injuries. You must wear side shields with your safety glasses.
- Safety goggles and face shields for the following types of work are **mandatory:**
  - Handling or pouring acid or other corrosive chemicals.
  - Using an emery wheel or grinding, riveting, chipping, or sandblasting equipment.
  - Using compressed air for cleaning (see restrictions on the use of compressed air in Section V, Paragraph F).
  - Working in areas designated as rewrap operations, where eye hazards exist.
- Never wear contact lenses in the presence of corrosive or irritating materials, especially in battery-charging rooms.
- Wear proper eye protection of the correct shade when observing or performing welding operations. Use appropriate shielding to protect other employees' eyes from arc flashes. **Never** look at or in the direction of a welding arc without appropriate eye protection, as it can cause painful damage to your eyes.
- Make sure that the lenses of all eye protection devices are free from cracks, chips, or obscurities; replace or repair such lenses immediately.

2. Hand Protection

Your supervisor will select and require employees to use appropriate hand protection when employees' hands are exposed to hazards such as those from skin absorption of

harmful substances, severe cuts or lacerations, severe abrasions, punctures, chemical burns, thermal burns, and harmful temperature extremes.

Your supervisor will base the selection of the appropriate hand protection on an evaluation of the performance characteristics of the hand protection relative to the tasks to be performed, conditions present, duration of use, and the hazards and potential hazards identified.

- You are prohibited from using gauntlet-type gloves.
- You may use gloves for materials handling activities that do not involve potential contact with powered machine parts.
- You may use protective or barrier creams on your hands and arms if they are exposed to oils and greases, chemicals, or corrosive or irritating cleaning compounds. However, these creams are not a substitute for appropriate PPE.
- For additional information, see Management Instruction EL-810-2009-4, *Personal Protective Equipment and Respiratory Protection Programs*.

3. Head Protection

- Wear appropriate head protection when your work exposes you to falling objects, when a risk of striking your head against low stationary objects exists, or when you are in an area designated for hard-hat protection (especially above floor level), and when indicated by PPE assessments.
- Where employees are not exposed to possible head injuries, head protection is not required by OSHA Standards.
- Regulation hats, caps, or pith helmets are recommended for protection from the sun or cold for employees working outdoors.

4. Hearing Protection

- You may be required to wear hearing protection if noise levels cannot be controlled to below OSHA limits. Safety and health personnel will provide a selection of approved hearing protection devices and assist you with the fit *and* care of the devices. Hearing protection will be made available if noise levels on your job exceed 85 decibels.
- Radio headsets are not a substitute for approved hearing protectors. Do not wear them in areas where hearing protection is required.

5. Respiratory Protection

- There may be situations where you are required to wear a respirator to protect you from exposure to toxic vapors, dusts, etc. Your supervisor or safety officer will provide approved respirators and instruct you, on the clock and on Postal Service premises, in the proper fit and use of your respirator.
- Keep your respirator clean, inspect it frequently as instructed, and store it in a clean place.
- If your job requires the use of a respirator, you will be evaluated by a medical officer to ensure that you can wear one safely.
- You may use a Filtering Facepiece type respirator for comfort whether it is your own or is provided by the Postal Service.
- If your job does not require use of a respirator, but you wear it voluntarily, your supervisor will provide you with a copy of Appendix D to OSHA 1910.134, *Information for Employees Using Respirators When Not Required Under the Standard.*

Section V: Housekeeping and Sanitation

Keeping your immediate work area clean is your personal responsibility. A neat and orderly work place is a safer place to work.

A. Personal Items

- Where a locker and changing room are provided, keep your locker clean, neat, and free from debris. Do not store items on top of your locker.
- Eat and store food and beverages only in authorized areas; do not store or consume them in restrooms.
- Dispose of food wastes, etc., only in receptacles intended for this purpose. You are responsible for disposing of your own food waste, wrappers, cans, etc.

B. Obstacles

- Keep aisles, passageways, stairways, exits, and all other walking areas free from obstructions at all times. Make sure that electrical panels, switches, fire-fighting equipment, exit doors, fire alarm stations, and postal inspector breakout doors are kept clear.
- Do not enter roped-off or marked areas where maintenance work is being done or where hazardous or slippery conditions exist.

C. Spills and Leaks of Hazardous Materials

- If a spill or leak occurs, notify your supervisor immediately. Alert others nearby and clear the immediate area. If the spilled substance is flammable, take every precaution to avoid possible ignition of the substance.
- Follow the Standard Operating Procedures (SOP) for cleaning up spills and leaks of hazardous materials. Refer to Handbook EL-812, *Hazardous Materials and Spill Response,* and to Material Safety Data Sheets (MSDSs) for information on chemical spills or leaks.

D. Tools and Other Portable Equipment

- Keep all tools and other pieces of portable equipment in their assigned places when not using them.
- Use safety glasses when operating power tools. Safety glasses must meet ANSI criteria.

E. Cleaning

- Never mix cleaning compounds. The chemicals used in them, such as chlorine and ammonia, when combined, can take on irritating or otherwise hazardous properties.
- Vacuuming is preferred to blowing down with compressed air. If blowing down is necessary, whenever possible, remove dust on or inside processing equipment and other surfaces by vacuuming an area prior to blowing it down.
- Rope off wet floor areas with high visibility safety marking rope and post *Wet Floor* signs until the floors are dry.
- Follow all vendors' instructions regarding equipment, materials, and supplies.

F. Using Compressed Air

- Use a vacuum rather than compressed air to remove dust, dirt, or other debris from your clothing or body. Using compressed air to blow dust, dirt, or debris off yourself is an extremely hazardous practice and is prohibited.
- Do not use compressed air to clean machinery or parts in mail processing areas. Use vacuum cleaners for this purpose. The most current maintenance policies and procedures should be followed. When compressed air is permitted for use, the air must be compressed to 30 PSI or less or use a hose that is equipped with a nozzle that will deadhead at 30 PSI or less.

Section VI: Machinery and Electrical Equipment

A. General Rules

- Treat all electrical circuits as *live* circuitry.
- Turn off all electrical equipment when you are not using it.
- Never overload an electrical circuit.
- Use Postal Service machinery and equipment only if you are trained and authorized to do so.
- Check equipment prior to use for good working order. Never operate defective machinery or equipment. Report all such machinery or equipment to your supervisor immediately. Complete and attach PS Form 4707, *Out of Order,* to all such equipment. Do not operate any equipment that has been orange/red tagged with this form.

B. Machine Guarding

Never operate machinery that is not properly guarded.

- Make sure that guards are in place on all drives, pinch points, and points-of-operation; keep all guards in place while the machine is in motion.
- Before starting machinery, make sure that everyone is in a safe place and that guards and safety devices are in working condition and are properly adjusted.
- Keep all guards in place, securely fastened, and maintained in a functional condition.
- Do not remove, replace, or adjust a guard on moving machinery or equipment.

- Do not use the *stop* button to try to lock out equipment; it is not effective as a lockout device.

C. Emergency Stop Buttons, Switches, and Cords

- You must be trained, on the clock and on Postal Service premises, in the use of emergency stop buttons, switches, and cords, etc., before you are assigned to a machine area.
- Keep all emergency stopping devices accessible, in plain view, and in operating condition. Report any defects to your supervisor immediately.

D. Conveyors, Sorters, and Other Mechanized Equipment

- Do not climb under or onto or cross over a conveyor, sorter, or other piece of mechanized equipment for any reason, unless the system is effectively locked out.
- Do not ride the equipment.
- Stop the equipment when freeing jams. Only trained maintenance personnel may clear a jam by going up on the equipment. Before clearing jams or working on this equipment, first lock out at the source of power. If two or more people are working on the equipment, they must all attach their own personal locks.
- Stop the equipment when you must search for or pick up an item underneath it. Make certain the equipment cannot be started unexpectedly, thus exposing you to danger.
- Do not attempt to retrieve fallen, misthrown, or caught mail from moving equipment.

- If a conveyor stops, call a mechanic; do not try to restart it by pulling the belt or by using any method other than the designated start button.
- Do not overload conveyors, sorters, or other mechanized equipment.

E. Cords

- Never splice or patch electrical cords; replace them. Shorten a cord only if you are qualified to do so.
- When you disconnect electrical equipment, pull the plug rather than the cord.
- As much as possible, keep extension cords off the floor. If it is absolutely necessary to put such cords on the floor, use Underwriters Laboratories (UL)-approved or other certified testing laboratory-approved temporary floor covers to prevent tripping on or damaging the cord.
- Remove and replace frayed or damaged electrical cords.
- Do not use extension cords as substitutes for permanent wiring.

F. Grounding

- If portable electrical tools are not double insulated and labeled as such, make sure they are equipped with a 3-wire plug. Never cut off the ground connection.
- If the ground prong has been removed, do not use the equipment or tool until the plug has been replaced.

G. Tools

- In areas containing a potentially hazardous or flammable atmosphere, such as battery-charging rooms or spray-painting booths, use only approved nonsparking tools and explosion-proof equipment.

H. Lockout Procedures

- Before working on power-driven equipment or electrical circuitry, follow lockout procedures and ensure effective lockout at the energy sources.

I. Defective Equipment

- Remove all defective equipment from service immediately; tag it with PS Form 4707, *Out of Order,* and take it to be repaired or to be stored in the designated area for defective equipment. **DO NOT USE** tagged equipment until it has been properly repaired.

Section VII: Lifting, Material Handling and Other Equipment

A. Lifting Guidelines

Lifting is so much a part of our everyday activity that most of us do not think about it, but it's often done incorrectly. The results can include strains, pulled muscles, disc lesions, or painful hernias.

Before lifting anything, check the immediate area and route of travel to be sure that no obstruction or hazard can cause a slip, trip, or fall, or a *striking against* accident.

The technique for proper lifting is simple:

- Assess the load. If it appears to be too heavy or bulky to lift comfortably, get help.
- Place one foot alongside the object being lifted and one behind. This method gives you greater stability and your rear foot gives you better upward thrust. Use the *sit-down* position and keep your back in a straight line (though not necessarily perpendicular to the floor). A straight back keeps your spine, back muscles, and organs in correct alignment and minimizes the compression of organs that can cause a hernia.
- Tuck in your chin so your neck and head are in a straight line with your back. That helps keep your spine straight and firm. It is not necessary, however, to force your chin against your chest.
- A palm grip is one of the most important elements of correct lifting. Keep your fingers and hands extended around the object you are going to lift, using your full palm. Fingers alone have very little power; you need the strength of your entire hand.

- Keep the load you are lifting drawn close against your body; tuck your arms and elbows against your side.
- When your arms are held away from your body, they lose much of their strength and power. Keeping your arms tucked in also helps keep your body weight centered.
- Position your body so that your weight is centered over your feet. This provides a more powerful line of thrust and also ensures better balance. Start the lift with a thrust of your rear foot.
- Avoid twisting during lifting; twisting is one of the most common causes of back injury. By simply turning your forward foot out and pointing it in the direction you are moving, you will avoid the greatest danger of injury.
- Do not fight to recover a dropping object or *lost load.* Get out of its way and let it fall.
- Sudden lifting or releasing of loads can cause stress to the spine and back muscles. Always lift, move, and lower with smooth motions.

B. Material-Handling Equipment

- Inspect ropes, chains, cables, slips, jacks, skids, and other hoisting and rigging apparatus before using them.
- Report damaged or defective ropes, chains, cables, slings, straps, or other material-handling equipment or components to your supervisor.
- Never lift a load and leave it suspended or unattended. Do not exceed the lifting capacity of hoisting devices for any reason.

C. Portable Utility Platforms

- Use portable utility platforms only if you are authorized to do so.

D. Hand Trucks, Hampers, and Containers

1. General Rules

- Do not ride, climb onto, or cross over any manually propelled rolling equipment.
- Push, rather than pull, all hand trucks, containers, hampers, and other such equipment. Your hands must not protrude beyond the sides of the container you are pushing. Do not manually tow containers.
- Never overload equipment or load it so high that it is top heavy.
- Place orange tags on defective equipment. Use PS Form 4707, *Out of Order,* to report all defective equipment. Report defective equipment to your supervisor, and remove it to a designated storage area.

2. Hampers

- Keep clear of hamper dumpers in use. Avoid placing heavy objects, sacks of mail, or mail in trays in hampers. Place heavy packages on flatbed trucks rather than in hampers. If you must remove a heavy package from a hamper, tip the hamper onto its side and lift the package from the floor to avoid excessive strain on your back. Use proper lifting techniques.
- Use a coupler or similar device when towing hampers.
- Tow no more than three hampers, whether loaded or empty.
- Never attempt to tow hampers by holding them with one hand while you drive the tractor.
- Never stack hampers more than three high, either for storage or transportation. To unstack hampers, always get help from another person. Turn the nested hampers onto their sides before unstacking them.

3. Containers

- The term *containers* refer to general purpose mail containers (GPMC), Eastern Region mail containers (ERMC), BMC over-the-road containers (BMC-OTR), etc.
- When manually loading or unloading a container, set the brake, if one has been provided. If the container does not have brakes, place mail or equipment into the container rather than throw it, because the container may move if jostled. Use at least two wheel chocks (front and back) to prevent movement when positioning a container on an uneven surface.
- Load the bottom shelf of a GPMC first. Unload it last. Use the restraining bar to hold the top shelf while it is in the raised position. When the container is not in use, store the shelves in the *down* position.
- Secure all containers that you load onto vehicles with shoring bars to prevent the load from shifting and rolling free. Place OTR-container tow pins in the floor sockets of trucks or vans.
- If a load has toppled against the mesh doors of an ERMC, get assistance when removing the restraining bar. When pressure is placed against the mesh door, the restraining bar can be *extremely dangerous* because it acts like a spring when released.
- Always hold restraining bars, doors, and shelves with one hand to prevent them from falling when released, and stand to one side.
- When moving an ERMC or GPMC, make sure that the center shelf is in the *down* position. Check the gate latch and shelf latch before loading or moving a container.
- Push containers from the swivel wheel end. Watch constantly for obstructions on both sides of the container.

E. Other Equipment

1226 F Tray Carts

- Prior to DBCS set up, inspect for damage to individual slide-out drawer, wheel brakes or for non-functional mechanical parts.
  - Conduct a visual check for loose and missing hardware, jagged or sharp edges.
  - Verify cams and tray plates are in the home position and that springs are not broken, missing, or loose.
  - Verify steering control lock and wheels on tray cart function properly.
  - Verify all warning labels are readable and in proper location.
  - Verify slide assemblies extend and retract properly.
- Report defective equipment to your supervisor and move it to a designated storage area.
- When cart is on an uneven surface, the brakes should always be in the locked position.
- Proper alignment of the tray shelves to the DBCS stacker levels will minimize excessive stretching, bending, and turning during sweeping.

Section VIII: Powered Industrial Trucks

Powered industrial truck (PIT) operators are responsible for ensuring vehicle safety and following all safety requirements. Make sure that operators are trained and authorized to operate PITs described in OSHA 1910.178, such as tow motors, fork trucks, platform lift trucks, motorized hand trucks, and other specialized industrial trucks powered by electric motors or internal combustion engines. All PIT-related accidents and near misses, including property damage, must be investigated and reported on a PS Form 1769/301. Fuel-powered industrial trucks are generally prohibited indoors. Consult with your local safety professional before using a fuel-powered industrial truck.

A. Operating Rules

1. General Rules

- Do not operate PITs in a reckless manner; this is strictly prohibited.
- Always wear your seat belt any time a PIT is in motion.
- Before using a PIT, check the brakes, steering apparatus, horn, etc. Report any defects to your supervisor immediately.
- Drive PITs at or below 5 miles per hour (about the speed of a fast walk). Use only the designated vehicle traffic lanes, and keep to the right when ever possible.
- Never use the reverse control as a brake.
- Never allow a passenger to ride on a PIT unless securely attached seating is provided. Never exceed the seating capacity of the unit.

- Never disengage, cover up, or bypass any audible or visual warning devices on powered industrial equipment.
- Do not ride with any part of your body protruding from the vehicle.
- Make sure that there is adequate clearance before you drive under any overhead obstruction.
- Approach all intersecting aisles and tow conveyor crossings slowly and cautiously. Sound your horn to warn pedestrians of your approach.
- Check to be sure there is a clear path to the rear before backing up.
- Stay at least three vehicle lengths behind other vehicles when traveling.
- Check bridge or dock plates for proper stability before you drive across them.
- Before dismounting, stop your vehicle, place the gear in neutral, set the brake, and turn the ignition off.

2. Lift Trucks

- Lift, lower, and carry loads on a lift truck with the lifting mechanism in a vertical position or tilted back - never forward.
- Face the direction in which you are moving and be careful of rear-end swing when turning corners.
- When approaching or leaving a building where the ramp incline is greater than 10 degrees, turn the lift truck so the load is on the upgrade side and cannot slip off the forks.
- Keep forks on a moving lift truck low (just high enough to clear any floor obstructions and low enough to clear overhead obstructions). Under normal conditions, 3 to 6 inches above floor level should be sufficient.
- Do not raise or lower forks while the forklift is in motion.

- When you park a lift truck, fully lower the forks, put the controls in neutral, shut off the power, set the brake, and remove the key.
- Before entering a truck or trailer with a forklift, inspect the floor for damage or decay which might cause the lift to break through.
- Make sure that the truck or trailer wheels are properly chocked or secured by a mechanical vehicle restraint system before entering the vehicle with a forklift.

B. Warning Devices and Protective Equipment

- Be sure that any powered industrial vehicle you operate is equipped with a horn and a flashing warning beacon that is in working order.
- Do not operate industrial lift trucks with the overhead guard or load backrest removed.
- PIT drivers must wear personal protective equipment as specified by the local PPE assessment. PIT drivers must also wear hard hats when working in designated hard hat areas.

C. Towing Wheeled Equipment

- Use only approved tow bars or coupling devices for towing wheeled equipment. Do not use your hand to hold equipment being towed.
- Tow only three platform trucks, hampers, or containers (GPMC, ERMC, BMC-OTR) whether loaded or empty.
- Attach no more than five containers to a driverless tractor unit or automatic guidance vehicle (AGV).

D. Towing Wheeled Equipment — 12 Foot Aisle Facilities

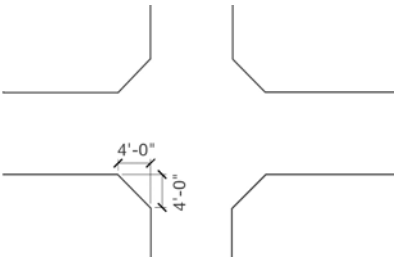
This section applies only to the following Logistics and Distribution Centers (L&DCs) and Priority Mail Processing Centers (PMPCs) at the following locations:

Phoenix, Arizona	Northern New Jersey
Jacksonville, Florida	Bethpage, New York
Miami, Florida	Rochester, New York
Orlando, Florida	Philadelphia, Pennsylvania
Springfield, Massachusetts	Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania
Nashua, New Hampshire	

A maximum of seven general purpose mail containers (GPMCs) and/or Eastern Region mail containers (ERMCs) may be towed at any given time provided that the following criteria are met:

- All aisles are clearly marked.
- The aisle width must be a minimum of 12 feet to allow two-way traffic to pass; any aisle less than 12 feet wide requires one-way traffic or no passing of container trains.
- All 90-degree intersections are required to be chamfered by 4 feet at a minimum (see below).

Chamfered Intersection

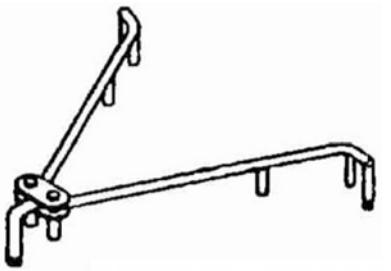


- All L&DC and PMPC sites are required to purchase and install Electronic Speed Control (ESC) Programmers on all existing PIT vehicles before instituting an increase of towing more than three mail containers within the facility. The ESC setting is to be adjusted to approximately 80%, not exceeding 5 mph with the powered industrial vehicle (PIV).
- All newly purchased PIVs must have the ESC devices installed by the manufacturer according to the specifications mentioned above.

When towing more than three GPMC and/or ERMC containers at one time, the PIT operator must place a folding tow bar (shown below) between the third and fourth container. When towing a train of seven containers at one time, the PIT operator must use two folding tow bars. One will be placed between the third and fourth container as previously mentioned and the other will be between the fifth and sixth container (i.e., in a 3-2-2 pattern).

When towing containers, the PIT operator must use the brake levers to prevent jackknifing or loss of containers in the train.

Folding Tow Bar



E. Repairs

Repair Postal Service vehicles only if you are a qualified and fully trained employee.

(See Handbook PO-502, *Container Methods,* for further information on proper use of mail equipment.)

Section IX: Mail Delivery

A. Fingering Mail

- Never finger mail while driving, walking up and down steps or curbs, crossing streets, or at any other time the practice could create a safety hazard to you or the public.

B. Hazardous Conditions

- Pay close attention when you are walking in order to avoid lawn depressions, stones, bits of wood, children's toys, and other tripping hazards.
- You are not required to risk personal injury from icy steps, broken or rotten steps or porches, protruding nails or sharp edges on mailboxes, or similar hazardous conditions. Use PS Form 1767, *Report of Hazard, Unsafe Condition, or Practice,* to report any of these problems to your supervisor.
- Alert replacement carriers to any hazardous conditions by completing PS Form 1766, *Hazard Warning Card.*

C. Mail Collection

- When collecting mail from a street box or a mail chute receiving box, or when delivering mail to apartment house boxes or neighborhood delivery and collection box units (NDCBUs) that are equipped with an arrow lock, remove the key from the lock to avoid personal injury or damage to your clothing or keys.

- Keep the chain for your mailbox keys securely fastened to your belt loop and place the keys and chain in your pocket when you are not using them. Dangling, swinging keys and chains can be dangerous.
- Use PS Form 1767 to report defective, dented, or unanchored collection or relay boxes to your supervisor so that corrective action can be taken. Do not try to force entry to dented or otherwise defective collection or relay boxes.
- Always check the contents of mailboxes for broken glass, bottles, insects, or animals before placing your hands inside.
- Never stand in the street when loading or emptying mailboxes. Do not place mail in or collect mail from any boxes that require you to stand in the street. Use PS Form 1767 to report such boxes to your supervisor so that corrective action can be taken.

D. Animals and Insects

1. General Rules

- You are not required to deliver mail when an animal threatens you. Use extra care in making deliveries when dogs or other animals are loose on your route.
- Prepare PS Form 1778, *Dog/Animal Warning Card,* and place it in the letter case whenever you observe an animal that may interfere with the delivery of the mail. Place the card in front of the address where the hazard has been observed. In a situation where the dog poses a threat throughout a segment of the route, case the card at an address most appropriate to provide advanced warning.

- In addition, report any such interference to your supervisor so that the customer may be notified that the animal must be restrained.
- Never antagonize a dog. Never attempt to pert or feed a dog. If a dog rushes toward you or takes you by surprise, do not run. Retreat very slowly, facing the dog. Keep your mail satchel between you and the dog as a first line of defense. Be careful not to stumble over objects as you retreat.
- Use dog repellent spray only if you are attacked. Spray it directly at the dog's eyes, nose, and mouth. Do not use dog repellent indiscriminately or when there is danger of spraying children or adults.
- When delivering mail through a door slot, keep your fingers out of the slot; an animal may be on the other side.
- When delivering mail to a customer's door, keep your foot on the door so that a dog cannot unexpectedly rush out at you.
- If rabies has been officially reported in the community where you are delivering mail, be especially observant of any dogs, cats, or wild animals.

2. Medical Treatment of Animal Bites or Insect Stings

- If you are bitten, get medical treatment immediately, regardless of the severity of the injury. Even small bites or contact with animal saliva can transmit rabies. Wash the area with soap and water as soon as possible.
- If you have severe or allergic reactions to insect stings, you must inform your supervisor and, if available, the medical or health unit. Use caution in removing mail from mail receptacles to avoid stings from any insects inside.

Section X: Motor Vehicles

Vehicle accidents are a major source of serious personal injury for Postal Service employees. Defensive driving is the best way to prevent vehicle accidents because it involves both the desire and the ability of a driver to control accident-provoking situations. You are expected to drive all Postal Service vehicles in a dependable, efficient, safe, and courteous manner.

A. Licenses

- Only authorized personnel can operate Postal Service vehicles. You must have in your possession a valid state driver's license when operating a Postal Service vehicle or any vehicle when on Postal Service business. State driver's licenses are not required for operating PITs on Postal Service premises.
- You must inform your supervisor immediately if your state driver's license is revoked or suspended.
- The Department of Transportation (DOT) regulations mandate alcohol and drug testing of employees with commercial driver's licenses (CDLs). The Postal Service has implemented this requirement in Management Instruction PO-720-2010-1, *Alcohol and Drug Testing of Employees With a Commercial Driver's License (CDL).*

B. Civil Laws

- You must obey all state and local traffic laws when driving any Postal Service vehicle. You will receive no special privileges or rights as a Postal Service driver. Police citations for traffic violations are your personal responsibility. Promptly report them to your supervisor while on duty.

C. Reporting Accidents

If you are involved in an accident:

- Stop at the scene.
- Aid or assist any injured person.
- Have someone call for an ambulance or the police, if necessary.
- Safeguard the scene against any further accidents.
- Safeguard the mail.
- Try to identify several witnesses.
- Promptly notify your supervisor.
- Follow the instructions in your Item 087-H, *Accident Report Kit,* and any local accident reporting instructions.

D. Vehicle Regulations

1. Vehicle Safety Inspections

- Make a daily safety check of your assigned vehicle as outlined in Notice 76, *Expanded Vehicle Safety Check*, before leaving the post office parking lot or garage. Inspect leased trailers for damage or placards that may not be appropriate, such as flammable or hazardous waste, etc.
- Check to make sure that a sealed *Accident Report Kit* (Item 087-H) is provided inside your assigned vehicle.
- Use PS Form 4565, *Vehicle Repair Tag*, to report all mechanical defects, failures, and vehicle damage to your supervisor.
- Handbook PO-701, *Fleet Management*, 243.1 requires that vehicles of one ton or larger that are regularly scheduled for intercity or airport runs or vehicles regularly scheduled for use as wreckers must carry fire extinguishers and emergency warning device kits.

2. Safety Belts

- You must wear safety belts at all times the vehicle is in motion. When driving a long-life vehicle (LLV) or the carrier route vehicle (CRV), you must wear the lap belt and shoulder belt whenever the vehicle is motion.

  Exception: When shoulder belts prevent you from reaching to deliver or collect from curbside mailboxes, you may unfasten the shoulder belt, but never the lap belt.

- You may carry only authorized passengers. All passengers must remain seated and wear a lap belt and shoulder harness whenever the vehicle is in motion.
- Rural carriers must follow the policy outlined in Handbook PO-603, *Rural Carrier Duties and Responsibilities*, 171.5.
- Some administrative Postal Service vehicles are equipped with airbags that may deploy upon frontal impact.

3. Doors

- When you are traveling to and from your route, when you are moving between park and relay points, and when you are entering or crossing intersecting roadways, you must be sure that all vehicle doors are closed.
- All vehicle doors must be secured when the vehicle is left unattended and out of the driver's immediate sight.

  Exceptions: The Postal Service fleet includes a number of 1-ton, 2-ton, and 2.5-ton *step-van* style vehicles that have left-hand drive cab compartments with sliding doors, and closed cargo areas. When driving these vehicles, keep the rear door closed, and close the left door when the

vehicle is in motion. You may leave the right door open however, if there is no passenger, mail, or loose equipment in the cab area and the cargo partition is closed.

- When you are operating a vehicle on delivery routes and traveling in intervals of 500 feet (1/10 mile) or less at speeds no greater than 15 miles per hour between delivery stops, you may leave the door on the driver's side open. You must still close the door when traveling through intersections.

4. Fueling

- Shut off the motor before fueling a vehicle.
- Do not smoke within 25 feet of gasoline pumps, fuel, CNG, or oil storage tanks.
- Be sure the nozzle of the pump hose touches the edge of the tank to avoid static sparking.
- When filling a portable container, make sure it is on the ground and the nozzle touches the edge of the container.
- Know where the emergency shut-off switch for the fuel pump is located.
- Be sure that a fire extinguisher is located nearby.

5. Engine Exhaust

- The gas called carbon monoxide that is released by internal combustion engines is odorless, tasteless, colorless, and deadly. Therefore, hook up an exhaust hose to any vehicle before running its engine inside a building, or make sure there is adequate ventilation.
- Check exhaust hoses periodically for splits, cracks, or other deterioration.

6. Tire Safety Cages

- To inflate or deflate tires mounted on split rims, place them in an approved tire safety cage. Mount or dismount split rim wheels only if you have been trained to do so.
- When inflating a tire in the safety cage, use a clip-on air chuck with a remote valve so that you can stand clear.

E. Driving Regulations

1. General Rules

- Never finger mail or hold it in your hands while you drive.
- Move your vehicle only when you are absolutely certain that it is safe to do so, especially if children may be nearby. If necessary, get out, circle your vehicle, and check underneath it to make sure.
- Yield the right of way and make any other concessions necessary to avoid an accident.
- Always maintain a safe stopping distance, being especially careful during adverse weather.
- When following another vehicle in clear weather, you can judge the necessary distance between it and your vehicle by using the 4-second rule. Choose a landmark. When the vehicle ahead of you passes it, begin to count, *one thousand and one, one thousand and two, one thousand and three, one thousand and four.* If you pass the landmark before you reach *one thousand and four*, you are following too closely. During adverse weather, stay farther behind the vehicle in front of you. If you are following larger trucks (1-ton or more), increase the time lapse to 6 seconds.
- Use your turn signal before turning, changing lanes, or pulling to or away from the curb or shoulder of the road.

- Enter all unregulated or unprotected intersections slowly and cautiously. Slow down and do not enter the cross street until you are sure you can do so safely.
- Before entering any intersection, slow down and look left, then right, then left again. Remember that danger is always closer from the left when the roadway is two directional.
- Never wear headphones or headsets or any other device that can diminish your hearing while you are operating a motor vehicle.

2. Speed

- Always drive at a safe speed. Never exceed the speed limit, but keep in mind that under certain conditions the posted speed limit may not be the safe one.

3. Backing Up

- Avoid backing up whenever possible. If you can, park where you will not have to back up to pull away from a parking place. If you must back up, first walk around your vehicle to make sure there are no pedestrians, children, obstructions, etc., in your way.
- When backing a large vehicle, have someone guide you whenever possible. The guide should stand to the side and rear of the vehicle and use hand signals, not oral directions. Never allow the guide to get out of your vision, especially behind your vehicle; you might unknowingly crush the guide against some object. Even when you use a guide, it is your responsibility to back up safely. Use both rear-view mirrors and have them properly adjusted.
- Drivers who are required to turn a vehicle around in one continuous operation (such as rural carriers making turnarounds) must use extreme caution when backing up.

- Look, listen, and live at all railroad crossings.
- Obey all highway rail-crossing warnings.

4. Parking

Whenever the driver leaves the vehicle, the vehicle must be parked. To park the vehicle:

- Apply the foot brake and place automatic transmissions in the park position. Place manual transmissions in gear. For PVS vehicles 7 ton and above, place the transmission in neutral.
- Turn the vehicle's front wheels toward the curb if you are on a flat surface or the vehicle is facing downhill. If the vehicle is parked facing uphill, turn the front wheels away from the curb.
- Set the hand-parking/emergency brake. For PVS vehicles 7 ton and above, the parking air brakes must be applied.
- Turn off the engine and remove the key.
- Lock any sliding door(s) between the truck body and cab.
- Lock the doors if you will be out of direct sight of the vehicle.

5. Passengers

- Ride in Postal Service-owned, GSA-owned, rental, or contract vehicles (including employees' privately owned vehicles when used in Postal Service operations) only if you are authorized to do so. All passengers must use safety belts.
- If conventional passenger seats are not provided, use an approved auxiliary seat that faces forward and is equipped with a backrest and safety belts. Never stand in a vehicle that is in motion.

6. Loading

- Make sure that any mail you load into a vehicle will pose no hazard to the operator when the vehicle is started, stopped, turned, or otherwise operated on a mail delivery route. Do not place large parcels, bulky items, or bundles of mail on the tray or ledge to the extent that they can obscure your vision or break the windshield during a sudden stop.
- Always use proper lifting techniques when loading mail into a vehicle.

7. Parking Lots

- Park in designated parking spaces only.
- Use designated traffic lanes only.
- Observe posted speed limits. Unless posted otherwise, the maximum speed is 10 mph.
- Follow one-way directional signs in traffic lanes.
- Observe traffic signals when entering and leaving Postal Service premises.
- Do not throw litter in parking lots. Use receptacles that are provided.
- Obey all posted signs in the parking and access road areas.
- Do not park in or block fire lanes.

Section XI: Air Mail Facilities/Centers

The complex nature of airport operations can pose special dangers to Postal Service employees. Learn to recognize and be aware of hazards that may arise from aircraft, intense noises, and fueling operations. These hazards can be overcome by proper training and constant awareness.

A. General Rules

- Only ramp employees who are trained and certified with aircraft operation area access can be authorized to operate Postal Service vehicles on airport property.
- Postal Service employees are responsible for complying with all local Federal Aviation Administration aircraft operations area and ramp safety regulations.
- Smoking is not permitted in Postal Service facilities including air mail facilities. Do not smoke on airport service ramps or in the vicinity of pouch racks. Smoke only in designated areas.

B. Operator and Vehicle Regulation

- Before leaving your Post Office facility, make sure that your vehicle contains at least one-half tank of gas, a fully charged fire extinguisher, and any required emergency equipment.
- You must yield to all emergency vehicles responding to an alert. This includes crash and rescue vehicles, fire trucks, security or police cars, etc.
- Use only the exact travel route designated by the local airport authority and provided by your supervisor to reach the point of entry to an airport service ramp.

- Approach an aircraft only after all engines and propellers have been completely stopped. Your vehicle may not come any closer than 5 feet (or greater distance as dictated by the local airport authority) to any part of the aircraft.
- Never drive across passenger loading lanes while an aircraft is at a gate position.
- Always wear ear protection devices in the presence of operating aircraft.
- The tail end of an aircraft can be as hazardous as the front. Running engines blast dirt, debris, and other solid objects with a force strong enough to break windshields and to cause eye injury or bone fracture. Take immediate shelter if you are about to be caught by a blast from the engines of an arriving or departing aircraft.

Section XII: Seated Keying Activities

The following guidelines concern the adjustment of workstations for seated keying activities conducted over an extended period.

A. Workstation Chairs

Adjust a workstation chair within its limits. Sit with:

- Body and head erect.
- Upper arms vertical.
- Lower arms comfortably horizontal.
- Wrists on even line with the forearms.
- Thighs comfortably horizontal.
- Lower legs vertical.

B. Keyboards

- If the height of the keyboard can be adjusted, position the home row keys at approximately elbow height so that keying can be performed with the wrist on an even line with the forearm. The elbow should be at an approximate 90-degree angle.
- If the height of the keyboard cannot be adjusted, the chair height should be set so that the elbow is approximately the same height as the keyboard home row and the wrist is on an even line with the forearm.

C. Monitors

- Adjust monitor screen a suitable distance (normally, approximately 18ð—24ð) from your eyes when in use, with the top of the screen at, or a little below, eye level. Specific monitor placement may depend on your visual acuity and corrective eyewear.
- Adjust image color, brightness, and contrast. When possible, select a white or light background screen color and a dark color for text. This helps to reduce undesirable screen glare and reflections from overhead lights and light-colored clothing.
- Position the screen face to avoid glare and keep your field of vision free from glare sources.
- Clean screen periodically to eliminate smudges and dust.

D. Footrests

- Where a footrest is provided, adjust it to maintain support of thighs and lower legs. Keep feet flat and thighs horizontal to provide additional support for feet and legs.

E. Work Practices

- Rest your eyes periodically - blink, look away from the screen, stand up, and stretch.
- If you need to handle papers, the computer mouse, or other objects frequently in your work, try to position them as close to you as practical to minimize excessive reaching.

F. Rotation

- Follow established rotation and/or break schedules.

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